

**Review question**

What are the consonant sounds of the Witsuwit'en writing system which are spelled with an **h** in them?

What are the consonant sounds of the Witsuwit'en writing system which are spelled with ' in them?

Try to read the symbols.

## Answer to review question

What are the consonant sounds of the Witsuwit'en writing system which are spelled with an **h** in them?

**h lh yh kh wh gh**

What are the consonant sounds of the Witsuwit'en writing system which spelled with ' in them?

**' t' c' k' ts' tl' kw'**

Try to read the symbols.

## ï

A quick way to type **ï** in Microsoft Word documents is: ctrl-;, i. (Hold down Ctrl, then Shift-;, release and quickly type **i**.) For **Ï**, keep holding down Shift key while typing **i**.

This symbol is one of the differences between the Witsuwit'en writing system and the U'in Wit'en (Babine) writing system.

## Examples of ï

The vowel **ï** is usually found either at the beginning of a word or after the following consonants:

|   |   |    |    |   |    |    |
|---|---|----|----|---|----|----|
| b | d | dz | dl | g | gw | gg |
| m | n | z  | l  | y | w  | gh |

The vowel **ï** is rare after the following consonants:

|   |    |     |     |    |     |    |   |
|---|----|-----|-----|----|-----|----|---|
| p | t  | ts  | tl  | c  | kw  | k  |   |
|   | t' | ts' | tl' | c' | kw' | k' | ' |
|   |    | s   | lh  | yh | wh  | kh | h |

## ï vs. i

The symbols **i** and **ï** are similar letters, but the sounds are fairly different in terms of their distribution in Witsuwit'en, in other words, where they can occur in a word. As just mentioned, **ï** can occur at the beginning of a word (with no preceding consonant), but **i** cannot. At the end of a word, **i** must be followed by a consonant, but **ï** need not be. Also, **ï** cannot be followed by **k**, **kh**, or **gh** at the end of a word, but **i** can be.

Compare the following contrasts between **i** and **ï**:

bilh 'sleep; with him/her/it'  
dildlit 'he's hollering'

bïlh 'net, snare'  
dïldlit 'he was hollering'

|                                                                        |                                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| dinī ‘man, person, people’                                             | dīnī ‘four people’ <sup>3</sup> |
| dinīh ‘kinnikinnik’                                                    | dīnīh ‘say it’                  |
| bilits ‘its urine’                                                     | bilīts ‘its dust, ashes’        |
| bibit ‘his/her abdomen’                                                | bīt ‘lake trout; in it’         |
| dilh ‘with oneself’, as in:<br>dilh neyeldic ‘he’s talking to himself’ | dīlh ‘crane’                    |

## Stress

When words contain two or more syllables, putting the stress on the right syllable is important for good pronunciation. Otherwise, speakers may not understand what you’re trying to say. But what exactly is stress? It is mostly about how you say the vowel of the syllable. Vowels of stressed syllables are louder, longer, and higher in pitch than vowels of unstressed syllables.

### Rules for stress placement

Stress is not something that is indicated in the Witsuwit’en writing system, because it is something that is predictable. But there is more than one rule for stress placement. Here four rules for stress placement will be introduced.

(1) When a word has two syllables, and the vowel of syllable in the word is **i**, the main stress in the word falls on the second syllable:

hinic ‘language’  
hine ‘he/she/it is alive’  
hits’il ‘it’s barbecuing’  
dinī ‘person, man’  
dicin ‘stick, wooden’  
dic’ah ‘into the bush’  
bit’ak ‘his/her back’  
bikwit ‘his/her knee’  
bile ‘his/her hand’  
sisgiz ‘I’m breathing’  
sisc’is ‘I snapped it’  
sisc’ey ‘I shot it (once)’

(2) When the first vowel of a two-syllable word is a vowel other than **i**, then the strongest stress falls on the first syllable:

detic ‘door’  
tsalic ‘squirrel’  
īzlhiy ‘horse’  
dede ‘sickness’  
sunye ‘money’

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<sup>3</sup>dīnī also means ‘you say’ or ‘his/her own mind’, as in ’adic dīnī yī yelhdic ‘he’s speaking his own mind’.

yebegh ‘coast, horizon, overseas’  
 halho ‘cloth’  
 tēsdlī ‘steelhead’

(3) The syllable that carries the most content of a word, the root, must be stressed. The root is usually the final syllable of the word, but sometimes it is the second syllable from the end of the word when there is a suffix. (Sometimes a root is larger than one syllable too.) Compare:

dik, ndik ‘straight up’                      bidiggit ‘above him/her’

Using underlining to mark the stress, stress falls on the middle syllable of bidiggit because that is the part of the word that means ‘up’, and –it is a suffix meaning ‘place’. Compare also:

ndin ‘this person’                      ndinī ‘these people’

The strongest stress in ‘these people’ is on the first syllable in ndinī because ndin is the root ‘this person’ and –nī is a suffix marking plural. There are only a very small number of suffixes containing vowels in Witsuwit’en.

(4) A compound word is one which contains two roots. In compounds, each root is stressed and the leftmost root has the strongest stress. Compounds are written with a space between each root:

sis tsiy ‘bear meat, meat from black bear’  
sis ghī ‘bear grease’ [recording note: ghī is correct]  
sis mī ‘black twinberry’ (lit. ‘bear’s berries’)  
Sis Kwah ‘Harold Price Cr.’ (lit. ‘bear’s river’)

### Question

Now read the following words. The stressed syllable or strongest stressed syllable is underlined for you. Try to say which rule for stress applies to each member of the pair:

|                                       |                                                              |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| dinī ‘person, man’                    | <u>ndi</u> nī ‘these people’                                 |
| dinī ‘person, man’                    | dinī <u>y</u> u ‘people’                                     |
| sis <u>gg</u> uh ‘I grabbed it’       | <u>sis</u> gguh ‘black bear deadfall’                        |
| dig <u>gi</u> z ‘it’s crooked’        | bi <u>ni</u> ggit ‘upriver from him/her’ (cf. nik ‘upriver’) |
| <u>de</u> tic ‘door’                  | k’ <u>int</u> i ‘it’s broken in two’                         |
| ts’ <u>i</u> n k’it ‘cemetery, grave’ | hil <u>k</u> ’it ‘it’s swelling up’                          |
| sil <u>hts</u> ’ec ‘pepper’           | hol <u>hts</u> ’ec ‘nettles’                                 |

## Answer to question about stress rules

Try to say which rule for stress applies to each member of the pair:

dini ‘person, man’

rules:

skip word-initial **i**

ndini ‘these people’

-ni a suffix, so not stressed

dini ‘person, man’

rules:

skip word-initial **i**

diniyu ‘people’

skip word-initial **i**, skip suffix **-yu**

sisgguh ‘I grabbed it’

rules:

skip word-initial **i**

sis gguh ‘black bear deadfall’

stress first member of compound

diggiz ‘it’s crooked’

rules:

skip word-initial **i**

biniggit ‘uphill from him/her’ (cf. nik ‘uphill’)

skip word-initial **i**, skip suffix **-it**

detic ‘door’

rules:

stress leftmost vowel if other than **i**

k’intic ‘it’s broken in two’

skip word-initial **i**

ts’in k’it ‘cemetery, grave’

rules:

stress first member of compound

hilk’it ‘it’s swelling up’

skip word-initial **i**

silhts’ec ‘pepper’

rules:

skip word-initial **i**

holhts’ec ‘nettles’

stress leftmost vowel if other than **i**

## E and Ė

The sound represented by these two vowels is phonetically similar. Both sounds basically occur in English as well. Both of these vowels can occur at the end of a word with no following consonant. Neither of these vowels occurs at the beginning of a word (with no preceding consonant.)

### Examples of E

be’ ‘fully dry fish’

bet ‘mittens’

gen ‘here’

c’ene’ ‘maggot’

dede ‘sickness’

In Witsuwit’en **e** is rare after **kw kw’ wh k k’ kh h**.

### Examples of Ė

A quick way to type Ė in Microsoft Word documents is: ctrl-;, e. (Hold down Ctrl, then Shift-;, release and quickly type e.) For Ě, keep holding down Shift key while typing e.

This symbol is one of the differences between the Witsuwit'en writing system and the U'in Wit'en (Babine) writing system.

In Witsuwit'en, the vowel Ė only occurs after the following consonants:

|   |    |     |     |    |     |    |   |
|---|----|-----|-----|----|-----|----|---|
| p | t  | ts  | tl  | c  | kw  | k  |   |
|   | t' | ts' | tl' | c' | kw' | k' | , |
|   |    | s   | lh  | yh | wh  | kh | h |

tsĕ 'rock, stone'

t'ĕs 'charcoal'

tĕkh 'into, under water'

ts'ĕkh 'sinew'

cĕn 'summer'

### Words containing both E and Ě

tsĕghe 'hair (of the head)'

tl'ĕde 'last night'

tsentĕl 'ling, burbot'

bik'ĕ'et 'less than it'

tsĕk sde 'cast-iron pot with legs' (lit. it sits in the fire)

### E vs. Ě

lhenkit '(you) clap'

tselh 'axe'

'et 'there, then'

tsil tset 'toilet paper'

bilhtsen 'his/her brother'

hitl'et 'he/she is farting'

yust'et 'he/she liked it'

'ent'ah 'you're working'

\_\_wit'en 'person (of area)',

as in Witsuwit'en

lhĕnkit 'you, he/she clapped'

c'itsĕlh 'he/she is chopping something'

bi'ĕt 'without him/her/it'

tsĕt 'first time'

bitsĕn 'his/her shadow'

tl'ĕt 'night'

t'ĕt 'teenage girl'

'ĕnt'ĕn 'you worked'

'it'ĕn 'work, business'

### U vs. W

U and W are phonetically very similar sounds. In Witsuwit'en, u is often followed by a consonant and w is often followed by a vowel, as in the following examples:

uzi 'name'

wizi 'in the dark', as in wizi tĕstkiy 'it's getting dark'

unis 'way out'

winis 'more, than', as in winis 'ilco 'it's bigger'

uye ‘shy’  
 wiye wewiwhlhdzin ‘don’t make noise (you pl.)’

But in longer words **u** and **w** can occur in roughly the same environment, after a vowel and followed by a consonant, so learn to hear the difference and write **u** or **w** consistently. Compare:

deut’ën? ‘what does it look like?’  
 dewnīt’ën? ‘what does his/her face look like?’

weugeh ‘he/she isn’t shy’  
 wewdīt’ën ‘it’s marked, signed’

neundzīh ‘call his name again’  
 neundzī ‘you called his name again’  
 newtandzīlh ‘you’ll call his name again’

neuldiw ‘count it again’  
 dzītñits newdīnzit ‘it’s noon’

(In the first example of each pair, **u** is followed by exactly one syllable, and in the rightmost column, **w** is followed by two or more syllables.)

## Writing practice 2

|       |                          |
|-------|--------------------------|
| _____ | ‘all night’              |
| _____ | ‘bugger’                 |
| _____ | ‘flint’                  |
| _____ | ‘moss’                   |
| _____ | ‘spray’                  |
| _____ | ‘hide’                   |
| _____ | ‘warmth’                 |
| _____ | ‘his body odor’          |
| _____ | ‘his/her belly, abdomen’ |
| _____ | ‘it’s dirty’             |
| _____ | ‘I threw up’             |
| _____ | ‘clan donation’          |

When you have finished, compare what you wrote with your neighbor and try to come to some agreement.

**Answers to writing practice 2**

tits

c'il

bīs

yīn

sel

c'iziz

wizil

bizīl

bibit

ditsin

siskoy

hiwal

'all night'

'bugger' (as in 'en c'il yez 'that little bugger')

'flint'

'moss'

'spray'

'hide'

'warmth'

'his body odor'

'his/her belly'

'it's dirty'

'I threw up'

'clan donation'